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FBI Boston disbands organized crime unit

As N.E. Mafia fades into history, agents shift resources to more immediate threats

By Shelley Murphy
GLOBE STAFF

On an October afternoon in 1989, mobsters from Connecticut, Rhode Island, and Massachusetts gathered at a modest home in Medford for a secret ritual: the induction of four soldiers into the New England Mafia, which marked a new beginning after their underboss was killed by a renegade faction.

"It's going to be the life of the heaven," consigliere Joseph "J.R." Russo promised the new recruits, who pricked blood from their trigger fingers, burned holy cards, and promised to kill anyone — even their own sons if necessary — to protect La Cosa Nostra, Italian for "This Thing of Ours." As an FBI bug recorded the infamous ceremony, a historic moment for the law enforcement agency, Russo boasted that the secret Sicilian-born organization had thrived for seven generations, spreading to New York, Boston, Providence, Hartford, Chicago, and other cities across the country.

Those days are gone, according to former law enforcement officials and organized crime experts.

So much so that the FBI's Boston office, which oversees much of New England, quietly disbanded its organized crime squad recently and reassigned agents to other priorities, according to

FBI, Page A6



FBI surveillance taped suspects — Raymond "Junior" Patriarca (left) and Angelo Mercurio — arriving at a Mafia induction ceremony on Oct. 29, 1989, in Medford.

Healey pivots on work with Trump

As governor, she adopts less confrontational tone, talks of ways to cooperate

By Samantha J. Gross and Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

Long before she ran for governor, Maura Healey made a national name for herself as one of Donald Trump's chief antagonists during his first stint in the White House. A regular on cable news, the then-attorney general repeatedly took on the first Trump administration, in literal court and the court of public opinion.

To date, she has taken a markedly lighter touch to the president-elect in the wake of his second electoral victory.

Healey has softened her tone as she grapples with the reality of having to govern a state that is reliant on billions of dollars in funding from the federal government.

In a sit-down interview with the Globe, she said Trump has the "prerogative to pardon" those convicted in the Jan. 6 assault on the US Capitol, expressed hope he would push through legislation overhauling the nation's immigration system, and declined to say whether she is worried for American democracy after warning it was "on the line" as she campaigned for Trump's Democratic opponent, Vice President Kamala Harris.

"My job as governor is to prepare for it, work with the incoming administration where we can,

HEALEY, Page A5



PHOTOS BY BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

Heather Harper of North Truro arranged the dining table in her Christmas-themed home.

O CHRISTMAS SPREE

All decked out! No, wait, there's space to squeeze in . . . one . . . more . . . ornament.



The Harpers' front yard gives a hint of the Christmas decor inside: holiday rugs, mugs, throw cushions, garlands, tchotchkes, and more.

By Beth Teitell
GLOBE STAFF

Heather Harper of North Truro has a real estate problem. Or, more specifically, her Christmas decor does. "Every surface is already covered," she said wistfully.

Arches, windows, the guest bathroom floor, the roof, the mantel, cabinet doors, the space under the TV, couches, corners, the yard, her desk, the floating shelves in her kitchen, the staircase, soap dispensers — all are already bedecked in holiday rugs, mugs, throw cushions, garlands, tchotchkes, icicles, ye olde scenes, cutesy plaques, centerpieces, lights, and gingerbread houses, leaving no room for anything new.

Even Nova, the Maltipoo, and her husband's taxidermied, wall-mounted bass are spoken for. "It's wearing a Santa hat," she said of the fish.

Pity for a moment — even if some spouses and roommates won't — decoristas who have run out of display space. Where critics see clutter and consumerism, electric bills and climate harm, they see only holiday joy, albeit ex-

ORNAMENTS, Page A6

Faithful flock to guard against deportations

Rush to find housing before Republicans assume power

By John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

NEWTON — A coalition of local religious and advocacy groups, fearful that President-elect Donald Trump will make good on his threat to carry out mass deportations, is mounting a fast-moving campaign to find housing for many newly arrived immigrant families who are shut out of the state's beleaguered shelter system.

►Refugees brace for a cut in the resettlement program again. A2.

In addition to seeking volunteers to open up their homes and finding private apartments for families, the group is trying to raise thousands of dollars to support them and provide legal support for people who live, work, and go to school in Massachusetts and who seek to stay in the country legally.

"We are taking the new [Trump] administration at their word, and even now there are asylum-seeking families with infants sleeping on the street because there is no room in our state's emergency shelter system," said the Rev. Laura Everett, execu-

CONGREGATIONS, Page A7

Jacked frost nippin'

Monday: Cold and sunny. High 25-30, low 21-26.

Tuesday: Flurries early. High 33-38, low 23-28.

Sunrise: 7:11. Sunset: 4:16.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C10.**

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A Navy jet was shot down over the Red Sea in a case of "friendly fire," US military officials said. **A4.**

Advocates are worried the FDA may lose its sense of urgency in banning electric-shock devices at a Canton school for people with self-injurious or aggressive behavior. **B1.**

Brockton firefighters mourned a colleague who died after suffering a cardiac arrest while responding to a call. **B1.**

The preppy Marblehead look? The town's oldest store aims to bring that yacht club-casual to landlubbers. **B1.**

The MBTA is seeking a new way forward in plans to revamp its commuter rail system, including switching to electric power, writes Jon Chesto. **D1.**

An uphill battle? Not anymore at resorts.

Some ski areas more accepting of those skinning up slopes

By Amanda Gokee
GLOBE STAFF

CONCORD, N.H. — They could take the easy way up, relaxing on the lift before gliding effortlessly down the ski slopes, carving smooth "s" turns in the snow, propelled by the helpful force of gravity.

Instead, some skiers at Cranmore Mountain Resort in North Conway are relishing an old-school challenge: "earning their turns" by getting up the hill under their own power.

Ski touring has long been a niche community in snow sports, where skiers use special bindings and climbing skins to access backcountry locations for a purer, less-commercial experience in conditions dictated by nature, not machines. But, while backcountry skiing has exploded in popularity in recent years, warmer weather driven by climate change has led to steep declines in snow cover around New England, making for

SKI RESORTS, Page A7

A BITTER FEELING



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

New England Patriots quarterback Drake Maye grimaced after tossing an interception in the end zone during a mistake-filled third quarter in Buffalo. The Pats, undermined by turnovers, lost to the Bills 24-21. **C1.**